

San Fairy Ann Cycling Club Newsletter

January 2026

Creator Lorna Stafford

Ready for 2026?



New Year. New You. 2026 rides & events inside.

Racing Squad Launch

Racing Update – 2026 Season

We're excited to confirm that **San Fairy Ann now has a Road Racing Squad** and will be taking part in races across Kent for the **2026 season**. This is a major step for the Club and a brilliant opportunity for members to get involved, on or off the bike.

Meet the Squad

You'll have a chance to meet some of the riders at the [Weald of Kent on 25th March](#), if you can make it. Come along, say hello, and see what Club racing is all about.

Key Racing Dates

- **CycloPark Race League** First event: **7th May**. SFA will be **the lead marshals** for the kick-off event. Let's make this a strong Cub turnout.
- **Club Time Trials**, Wednesday evenings at **Paddock Wood**. Starting **1st May**

- **Track Training 14th February** Details via the *SFA Trackies WhatsApp*. Or contact *Barbara Wiles* on +44 7394 162028.

How You Can Get Involved

Racing isn't just for racers. We need members to help with:

- **Marshalling**
- **Event support**
- **Promoting the team via social media**

If you're interested in **marshalling**, please message **Jonathan Leeson** in the **SFA Racing Paddock WhatsApp group**.

Stay Connected

To follow the racing team and get updates:

- Join the **SFA Racing Paddock WhatsApp group** (chat with riders, get race info, and behind-the-scenes updates)

If off-road is more your thing:

- **SFA Gravel & CX WhatsApp group** is active and welcoming.

Useful Links

- [British Cycling Events](#)
- [San Fairy Ann Racing Club](#)

We look forward to seeing you at an event soon — whether you're racing, marshalling, cheering, or sharing the story.

Weald of Kent – Club Night Out

Who's up for a night out?

Join us at the **Weald of Kent** on **Wednesday, 25th March at 7:00 pm** for a social evening packed with Club news, travel updates, and a major launch.

San Fairy Ann Cycle Holidays – Spain 2026

The first part of the evening focuses on **San Fairy Ann Cycle Holidays**, with full details of this year's **Spain trip**.

- Learn more about the location and planned rides

- Ideal for anyone already booked, or still thinking about it

Updates will be provided by **Sam Woodward (Sporta Group)** and **Steve Harmer, Director of Events**.

Racing Team Launch – 2026 Season

The second half of the evening is the **official launch of the San Fairy Ann Racing Team**.

- Introduction to the 2026 race programme
- Meet members of the team
- First, look at the **new race kit**

Jonathan Leeson, Race Director, will outline the plans and introduce the squad.

Please Register

To help us plan numbers, [please register for the evening](#) if you're coming along.

This will be a relaxed, social night, whether you're travelling, racing, supporting, or just curious. See you there.

If You Would Like to Know What's Happening at the Cyclo Park.



Here's a link to their new Newsletter. [RIDE NEWS - KEEP ON THE WHEEL@RIDECYCLOPARK](#)
CYCLING FOCUSED NEWS, HIGHLIGHTS, EVENTS, AND SHARING SUCCESS!

Dates to Lock In



AUDAX: IS THE YEAR FOR WOMEN?



Picture this: 50 years of Audax celebrated with 50km rides, aiming for 50 riders. That's the 50:50:50 challenge, and it's brilliant.

Here's what makes it special. Audax UK has kept the distance deliberately short. At 50km, it's achievable for most of us, whether you're a seasoned long-distance rider or curious about trying your first Audax event.

Why now? Why women?

Let's be honest, Audax has been a bit of a blokes' Club. But that's changing, and this anniversary year is the perfect moment to shift the balance. The shorter distance removes one of the barriers that's kept women away, and we want to see more San Fairy Ann ladies out there.

Everyone's welcome, of course, but ladies, this one's especially for you. Whether you've been eyeing Audax events from the sidelines or you're ready to give it a go, 50:50:50 is your invitation.

Read on to hear from two of our members about their Audax experiences...

WHAT IS AUDAX? A MEMBER'S GUIDE



1 - Collecting the Brevet card.

Audax is one of the world's largest long-distance cycling associations. Founded in 1976, it now has over 8,000 members.

What is an Audax ride?

It's not a race or a sportive – it's a non-competitive long ride to be completed within a generous time limit that allows for rests and food stops.

Routes vary from flat to challenging hills, with distances from 50km up to 1,400km (LEJOG). Popular distances are 100/200/300/400 and 600km. You need to be self-sufficient, using a route sheet or GPX file.

How it works

At the start, you'll receive a Brevet Card, your proof of passage. Along the route, you'll hit checkpoints (controls) where you might answer a question ("distance to...?"), get a receipt from a shop, or collect a stamp at a food stop. Hand in your completed card at the finish, and it'll be validated and posted back to you.

Rides start and finish at the same place – usually a village hall or scout hut – with refreshments at both ends. Routes use quiet country lanes suitable for road bikes, but they're not signposted.

How to enter

Find rides on the Audax UK website events calendar – dates, distances, and elevation for rides across the UK throughout the year.

You can enter as a non-member by registering for free. If you're a member of Cycling UK/British Cycling, tick the CUK box. If not, there's a £3 charge for third-party insurance. Audax membership costs £20 per year and includes their Arrivé magazine. Entry fees are usually around £10, a fraction of sportive costs. You'll get all the ride information a few days before.

Pre-ride preparation

- Check your bike: brakes, pressures, chain lube
- Download the route to your Garmin/Wahoo/phone
- Switch your device to kilometres (all Audax rides use km)
- Familiarise yourself with the route and control points
- Check the weather, pack wind/waterproofs if needed
- Bring water and snacks
- Take a puncture kit: 2 spare tubes, tyre levers, pump
- Front and rear lights recommended
- Bring a pen for your Brevet Card (or take photos at checkpoints)

On the day

Arrive early to collect your Brevet Card and enjoy the pre-ride atmosphere with tea, biscuits, bananas, sometimes even toast and marmalade!

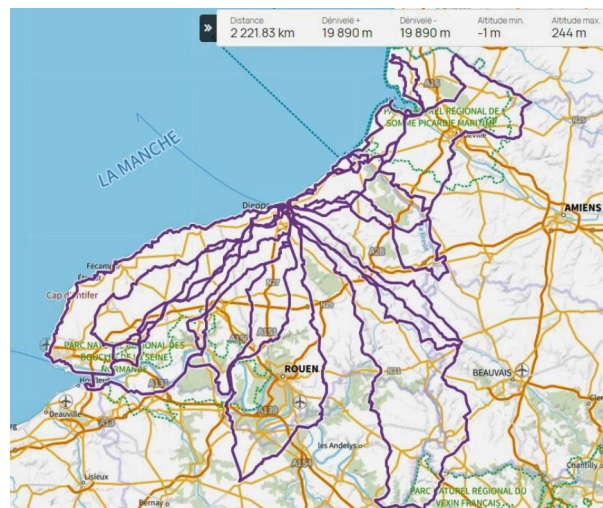
If it's a local or Club ride, you'll likely find fellow San Fairy Anns to ride with. Normal riding etiquette applies, just like a Club run. I've also done some rides solo in other parts of the country. You always meet people at food stops or can tag onto a group. Being non-competitive, people are friendly and relaxed. It's just a great day out!

I've completed 33 Audax rides in various parts of the country over the last 10 years.

Most important? Enjoy the ride!

By Brigitte Snook

NORMANDY STAR: A 2000KM ADVENTURE!





By our very own, King of Audax - Bob Watts

Turning up at the Normandy Star event HQ – a microbrewery on the outskirts of Dieppe – I immediately fell in love with the Frenchness of it all. All the info was in French, everyone spoke French, and there was a welcoming speech where the word 'courage' came up more

than once. On the side was a selection of cheeses, bread, and pickles. We were given a six-pack of beer brewed in the very same building.

Entries to the Etoile Normande were limited to a hundred, and I was the only Brit. The concept was brilliant: ten scenic loops from 170 to 300km covering eastern Normandy, choose one or as many as you like, pick up a validated ride of 200, 300, 400, 1000, 1200, or 2000km as long as you complete within the respective time limit. I went for the 2000km in 200 hours: nine rides in nine days. Quelle aventure!

Day 1: Into the Storm

270km west along the coast, climbing chalk cliffs and dropping into valleys, each with a little decaying seaside resort where visitors wore overcoats, dodging showers. The showers got heavier, and an enterprising pessimist had built an ark and left it by the side of the road. The headwind became stronger until the afternoon turned inland at Le Havre, when the tailwind made light of the showers until they became rivulets, then flooded roads.

Back at HQ in the small hours, the permanent 9-day picnic table was set out with local cheese, ham, salami, and sweet things. And importantly, a choice of salted or unsalted butter. Time for one beer from my six-pack before bed.

Days 2-3: Trains and Tourists

Day 2 took me 247km eastwards along the coast. The Baie de Somme preserved trains kept popping up everywhere, and more of those beautifully surfaced voie verte cycle paths on old railway lines. I wish I hadn't come across Valerie, though – Saint Valerie-sur-Somme was rammed with Sunday market tourists, delaying me half an hour. Otherwise, the roads were delightfully empty, and drivers were so unfailingly polite.

Day 3 was the longest route at 306km, to Giverny, where the gardens were overrun with tourists, and English seemed like the first language. All this fuss over some water lilies! The kiosk charged an inordinate sum for a snack, water, and coffee. Monet for nothing. That was a late finish, after midnight, but I knew it all got easier from here.

Day 4-5: Ancient Oaks and Swimming Cows

At Allouville, Bellefosse stood an immensely old but still living oak. Inside the hollow trunk is a chapel, and you can climb to the balcony. It's survived all these years, probably because it's next to a church and not a Toby Carvery in Enfield.

Day 5 took me to the Parc Naturel Régional des Boucles de la Seine, where I saw cows going for a swim in the estuary. A marvellous holiday outing with lots of seaside, quality cycle paths, and that steam train again! After the first day's downpours, the rest of the week was drier and warmer.

Day 6: The Turning Point

Day 6 is always the turnaround day for me. In longer events, I get weaker and slower until day 6, when I start getting stronger – when the body stops objecting and decides to get on with it. My accommodation was just 3km from HQ but at the bottom of a 70m high, 20% climb – an unerring measure of leg power each morning. Only on day 5 did I walk.

Day 7: Very, Very Old

This was architecture day. As I photographed a particularly run-down timber-framed barn, the dog started barking, and a man came out. Although standing under a bit of a roof that seemed destined to fall at any moment, he was keen to talk, so we chatted for 20 minutes. Sadly, he only wanted to talk about my bike ride, and I only wanted to talk about his farm buildings. His best guess of its age – even after some pressing – was "very, very old."

I was speeding up because a big storm was coming at eight. As lightning flashed and thunder crashed, I made it with minutes to spare.

Days 8-9: The Home Stretch

Day 8 was 228km heading southwest, where the week-long breeze helped me back. Delightfully rural, with manageable climbs to the 150m high chalk plateau before dropping into the next valley.

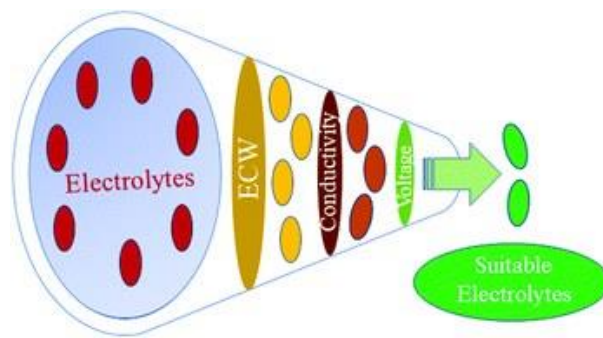
Day 9 was the shortest day and a lap of honour for the five of us choosing the 2000km brevet. For 170km, it was a photo and party day with ice cream and coffee stops. We were awarded a wooden brick memento and local fish soup at the end. How French.

This priceless experience cost just 65 euros – barely a fiver a day! It's held every Spring from a different town in Normandy. In 2026, it'll be from L ry-Poses. Really, there is nothing not to love. My name is already nailed to the start list for this May's Star Trek.

Save the Dates for 2026

- **SFA Birthday Party - 21st March - Marden**
- **Special Event with Guest Speaker - 25th March - Weald of Kent Golf Club**
- **13th May - Midweek Time Trails start - Paddock Wood**
- **The SFA Sportive - Sunday 24th May 2026**
- **28th June - Summer Audax - Bethersden Village Hall**
- **6th September - Autumn Audax - Chart Sutton Village Hall**

Why Add Electrolytes?



2 - by Emma Tuffey.

Electrolytes are **essential minerals** your body relies on to keep everything ticking over nicely, especially when you're on the bike. The main players are **sodium, magnesium, calcium, and potassium**, and they help with:

-  **Maintaining fluid balance**
-  **Muscle contraction & nerve signalling**
-  **Reducing cramps and fatigue**
-  **Supporting healthy blood pressure:**

Why do cyclists need them?

If you're riding for **more than 60 minutes**, cycling in **hot weather**, or putting in a **hard session**, you'll sweat out these vital nutrients.

 **Sodium is the first to go**, and low levels can lead to:

- Headaches
- Dizziness
- Nausea
- That horrible "no power in the legs" feeling

Shop-bought vs homemade

There are plenty of electrolyte drinks on the market, but:

- Many are **expensive**
- Some are packed with **artificial flavourings and extras you don't need**

Good news: you can make a simple, effective version at home. Just add these to your water bottle:

🍋 A slice of lemon

🧂 A pinch of salt

🍯 A teaspoon of honey

Simple. Cheap. Job done.

⚠️ A quick word of caution

Only use electrolytes when you're **actually going to sweat**. Taking them unnecessarily can cause a **salt build-up**, leading to bloating and potentially affecting blood pressure.

💧 Plain water still matters — think *balance*, not overload.

Ride smart. Hydrate smarter. 😊

Winter Performance.



3 - by Kevin Charlton

Get Fit Indoors This Winter!

Want to make the most of your indoor training this winter? Our Club coaches have launched a brilliant new programme to help you stay strong through the darker months.

How it works: Set yourself up on your turbo or trainer at home, then join a one-hour Zoom session every Monday at 6 pm. Tony Palmer, Kevin Charlton, and Geoff Wiles guide you through structured workouts, explain what you're doing and why, and answer your questions along the way.

What to expect: The 8-week programme started on 12 January and builds progressively week by week. Sessions focus on moderate to hard efforts (up to power zone 4 threshold),

so they're pitched at most Club riders, including those new to indoor training. While the coaches can help with individual questions, the sessions aren't tailored to specific riders.

Can I still join? The programme is open to all members, though jumping in mid-way means you'll face more challenging workouts from the start.

Questions? Contact Tony Palmer (Director of Training), Kevin Charlton, or Geoff Wiles (both British Cycling Level 3 coaches). More information needed? Email training@sanfairynncc.co.uk

Get pedalling – your spring legs will thank you!

The Excitement of Cyclocross!



4 - by Jeremy Roth

The forecast promised **wet, icy roads...** so naturally, we were welcomed by **blue skies and sunshine** instead. Classic cycling logic.

A band of **10 optimistic gravel riders** rolled out of Wateringbury at 10:00 am, tackling a route that was roughly **90% off-road**. The ride snaked through the woods and tracks of **West Peckham, Plaxtol, the Fairlawne Estate, Ightham**, and finally **Mereworth Woods**, confirming once again that **mud is not optional; it's inevitable**.

Mechanical gremlins came out to play with **not one, but two broken chains**. Thankfully, spare chain links saved the day and were fitted **faster than a puncture repair**, a rare and beautiful cycling miracle.

Even more astonishing... **There was no café stop** ☹️

Yes, we're still processing this.

Just before the finish, one rider decided to **test the laws of physics at speed**. The outcome:

✓ No broken bones

✗ One broken bike

✗ One slightly bruised ego

Despite the drama, it was a cracking ride all round, **sunshine, gravel, grit**, and stories that will definitely improve with every retelling.

Cyclocross: chaotic, muddy, and utterly brilliant.

SAN FAIRY ANN Captain of the Cups - Update.



We think we've already got a couple of people interested. But building a small *Cup Team* would make everything smoother, easier, and a lot more fun.

If you enjoy a bit of sparkle, ceremony, and being part of the club's big moments, this is a brilliant role to dip into. The Cup Team is the crew that keeps our trophies gleaming, our medals ready, and our Birthday Lunch feeling like the highlight of the year.

What the team does

- Look after the trophies and make sure they're engraved and ready
- Order medals from Afords in Bearsted
- Set up the trophy table for the Birthday Lunch so everything looks impressive
- Give the silverware a quick polish, so it shines on the day
- Make sure winners who can't attend still receive their awards

Why it matters

This is one of those behind-the-scenes roles that quietly hold the whole tradition together. Without a Cup Team, trophies stay tucked away, and the celebration loses its sparkle. With you, the club's history, pride, and sense of occasion stay alive, and every winner gets their moment.

Time needed

Just a little organisation around the Birthday Lunch. It's light on hours but big on impact.

If you'd like to be part of the fun (and help keep an important club tradition shining), please contact **John Longbottom on 07970 886565**.

A Fresh Start: Introducing the New SFA Club App! 📱



As the Club has grown, so has the amount of information we share — and with more of us checking ride details on our phones, it became clear that having a more mobile-friendly option would make life much easier. With that in mind, **Mark Phillipson** has created something designed exactly for how we plan and enjoy our rides today: the brand-new **SFA Club App. Fairies Little Helper**

The app brings all the essentials together in one simple, easy-to-use place:

- **Ride Group Calendars** – Quickly check upcoming rides for each group
- **Club Links** – Direct access to club resources and WhatsApp
- **Weather** – Local Kent weather at a glance
- **Groups/Settings** – Choose which ride groups you want to follow
- **Café List** – A handy guide to recommended cycling cafés
- **Specification** – Full details on how the app works
- **Feedback** – A GitHub link for suggestions or improvements

It's a fantastic step forward for the club, and we're incredibly grateful to Mark for the time, care, and expertise he's put into creating it. [For more details and to download click here:](#)

Members' Café Visit: Hever D&R Café



5 - by John Sells



A SFA member recently visited the **Hever D&R Café**, located on **Hever Road**, which is part of the **golf club**, and it comes highly recommended.

From first impressions, the **welcome is excellent**, with **plenty of seating both indoors and outside**, making it ideal for cycling groups.

The **coffee is among the best**, and the **cake is fantastic**, and not overpriced either. You genuinely get a **proper, generous slice**, not one of those “blink and it’s gone” portions. They also offer **hot meals, baguettes, and other savoury options**, so there’s something for everyone.

Orders are taken at your table, which is always appreciated after a ride. If a large group (around **20 riders**) turns up unannounced, there may be a short wait — but it's **well worth it**.

💡 **Top tip:** if you're heading there with a big group, it's best to **call ahead**.

Great coffee, great cake, and a cyclist-friendly welcome. Definitely one to add to the club café list.

Hever Rd, How Green, Edenbridge TN8 7NP. hever.drcoffeeshop@gmail.com

Member Contributions

A reminder!

This newsletter works best when it's **your voices**, not just mine.

If you've:



Been on a Club ride



Discovered a great café (or a terrible one...)



Found a cracking route



Taken photos worth sharing

...then send it in!

It doesn't have to be polished or poetic; **a few lines are plenty**. I can tidy it up if needed (that's my superpower).

If you rode it, ate it, broke it, fixed it, or laughed about it later, **we want to hear about it**.

Sharing is caring. And it saves me from making things up. 😊 So send it to Lorna on WA, or membership@sanfairynncc.co.uk

Looking Ahead

The 2026 Event Calendar is more extensive than ever this Year.

We will be calling out for help! We will need Marshals, Pit Crew, Bell Ringers, and Shouters!

This Club runs on people Thank you for being one of them.

Club Contacts

Duncan Edwards - Chair 07402 549927

Jonathan Engwell - Finance 07801 014877

Jonathan Leeson - Information Technology & Racing Team Lead - 07713 318186

Lorna Stafford - Membership & Events 07790 017482

Stephen Harmer - Events/Club Trips 07539 324565

Linton Schwarz - Club Kit 07901 851707

Bob Watts - Sportives & Audax - bobwatts999@gmail.com

Emma Tuffey Director Of Club Runs & Events - 07976 262260

Veronica Harmer - Club Secretary - 07910 265061

Tony Palmer - Training & Safety - 07786 393838